

Hazrat Ishaq

His Birth

When Hazrat Ibraheem  was about a hundred years old. Allah gave him the good news that from the womb of Sara a child was going to be born. His name should be given Ishaq. The Qur'ān states:

"And we gave her glad tidings of Ishaq and after him Yaqoob.

She said: "Alas for me! shall I bear a child seeing I am an old woman and my husband here is an old man. That would indeed be a wonderful thing."

The Angels said: "Dost thou wonder at Allah's decree? The grace of Allah and His blessing on you O ye people of the House.

For He is indeed worthy of praise, Full of
Glory." (11:71—73)

The Qur'ān also states:

Ibraheem  said: "Do you give me glad tidings that old age had seized me of what then in your good news?

They said: "We give thee glad tidings in truth.
Be not in despair."

He said: "And who despairs of the Mercy of his
Lord but such as go astray?"

Circumcision

When Ishaq ﷺ was eight days old, Ibraheem ﷺ performed his circumcision.

Ishaq (Alaihis Salām)'s Marriage

According to the Torah Ishaq ﷺ was married to a daughter of Nabi Ibraheem (Alaihis Salām)'s nephew and from this marriage two sons, Esau and Yaqoob ﷺ were born.

Esau got married to Nabi Ismail (Alaihis Salām)'s daughter Bishaamat or Muhallaat, while Hazrat Yaqoob ﷺ was married in the family of his maternal uncle.

Ishaq (Alaihis Salām)'s Mention in the Qur'ān

In the Qur'ān Hazrat Ishaq is mentioned in Surah Ambiyaa, Surah Maryam, Surah Hood and Surah Saffaat.

Hazrat Loot ﷺ

Loot and Ibraheem (Alaihimus Salām)

Hazrat Loot ﷺ is a cousin of Nabi Ibraheem ﷺ and during his childhood he used to live under the care of Sayeduna Ibraheem ﷺ and grew up in the house of Nabi Ibraheem ﷺ.

After Returning from Egypt

During Nabi Ibraheem (Alaihis Salām)'s *Hijrats* Hazrat Loot ﷺ and his wife always remained with him and while Ibraheem ﷺ was in Egypt they also were with him.

After Egypt Nabi Ibraheem ﷺ settled in Palestine while Nabi Loot chose to reside on the eastern side of the Jordan. There were two well known tribes in that area, viz Sodom and Ghamoorah.

The People of Loot

When Nabi Loot ﷺ settled on the Eastern side of the Jordan, he found that the people of the area were involved with great evils and sinful practices. No other worldly evil was there which were not found among them. Apart from the other sins they were also involved with a very bad practice that to satisfy their sexual lusts, the men instead of resorting to females chose to do so with other males. Up to that time in

the world, this was not practised anywhere. This was a very unfortunate group of people who invented this evil act. And what is worse than that, they did not look upon it as a sin and they proudly proclaimed their being involved with it.

The Qur'ān states:

"And we sent Loot. He said to his people: "Do ye commit lewdness such as no people mention over committed before you.

For you practise your lasts on men in preference to women. You are indeed a people transgressing beyond bounds." (7:80—87)

Hazrat Loot عليه السلام Conveying the Message

Nabi Loot عليه السلام preached to them about their shame less acts and iniquities and tried to get them towards a life of noble deeds and clean-living. In soft terms he tried to get them to heed his call explaining to them the results of previous nations as signs of warning but his call had no effect upon them. They replied by saying:

" And his people gave no answer but this; they said:

Drive them out of your city. These are indeed men who want to be clean and pure." (7:82)

This was a scornful and jeering manner of sarcastically playing the fool with the family of Nabi Loot عليه السلام. It was as if they said: If we are so shameless and evil and they are so clean and pure, there is no place for them in our city. Take them out. Expel them.

However Nabi Loot عليه السلام continued to advise them against those evils.

"Do you indeed approach men and cut off the highway.?

And practise wickedness even in your councils?

But his people gave no answer but this; they said:

"Bring us the wrath of God if you tell the truth."

(29:29)

Hazrat Ibraheem عليه السلام and the Angels

While this was happening to Nabi Loot, Nabi Ibraheem عليه السلام had an experience. He was walking in the desert and saw three men ahead of him. Ibraheem عليه السلام was a humble and hospitable man. He was always prepared to entertain guests and seeing these three strangers, he was quite happy. He invited them to his house where he slaughtered a calf and roasted the meat and placed it before the guests. They refused to eat and then Nabi Ibraheem عليه السلام thought they were enemies who according to custom would refuse to partake of food. He was frightened as to what this was. When the guests saw his confusion and worry, they laughed and said:

"Do not fear. We are Angels of Allah and have been sent to destroy the people of Loot. We are going to Sodom."

When Nabi Ibraheem عليه السلام was convinced that they were not an enemy but were in fact Allah's Angels, his soft-heartedness, sympathetic feelings and his love and Mercy was stirred and on behalf of the people of Nabi Loot عليه السلام he began to dispute with the Angels: "How can you go and destroy the people among which there is such a chosen Messenger of Allah like Nabi Loot عليه السلام."

The Angels replied:

"We are well aware of who are there but Allah has decreed that the people of Loot because of their evil deeds, their obstinate rebellion, and their shamelessness and there insistance on evil, will be brought to destruction while Loot عليه السلام and his family will be saved except the wife of Loot عليه السلام who, having assisted in their evil deeds and their wrong beliefs, will be destroyed with them."

In any case Nabi Loot (*Alaihis Salām*)'s efforts of conveying the truth to his people had no effect upon them at all, and they remained involved with their evil deeds.

He said to them:

"Do you not consider the fact that for my efforts of conveying the message to you by night and by day, and for my continuous worries on your behalf, I do not ask of you any payment or reward or any present?

All I seek of my efforts is your salvation and your worldly and spiritual success. And yet you pay no attention at all."

Even this too had no effect upon them. They continued to threaten him with expulsion and stoning to death. When at last there was no positive response from them, the same happened to them as is stipulated in the Divine law of Retribution which in their case also meant destruction.

The Angels after leaving Nabi Ibraheem (*Alaihis Salām*)'s presence proceeded towards Sodom where they became the guests of Nabi Loot عليه السلام. They were all in the

forms of handsome, young men. When Nabi Loot عليه السلام saw them he was worried as to what his people would do to these young men. At that time he had not yet been informed that they were Angels.

Hazrat Loot عليه السلام was still struggling with this fear when the people came to know of the visitors and came to his house, demanding that he should hand the guests over to them. He tried his best to dissuade them from this demand and asked them: "Is there not one rational reasonable man amongst you? Why are you so insistent upon this curse of seeking satisfaction for your lust in the company of men, leaving aside the women folk.

Alas, if only I had 'a strong pillar' on which to rely?"

When the Angels saw his greatly troubled state, they said to him:

"Do not look at our outer forms and be so worried. We are Angels from Allah, bringing His punishment. Allah's decree in their regard is fixed and will not be warded off from them. You and your family will be saved and protected from the punishment, except your wife who was an assistant to them. She will not be with you."

At last the punishment of Allah came. At a sign from the Angels, Nabi Loot عليه السلام and his family left the town. His wife refused to be with them, and along the way out, she turned back and left them for return to Sodom.

Then in the later part of the night, a frightening cry turned the people upside down. Then an earthquake took place in which the upper crust of the earth was taken up and turned down upon them. From above stones rained down

upon them and destroyed the town so that not a sign of them was left. And so happened to them what happened to other rebellious disobedient nations.

Ibraheem ؑ the Reformer

From the various incidents related here apart from the fact that there are lessons and warnings for men, another important point that comes to the fore is the fact that the personality of Hazrat Ibraheem ؑ in the office of Prophet hood and messenger ship holds a position of superiority and seniority.

It is the true that every messenger of Allah is a caller towards the oneness of Allah and is an enemy of '*shirk*' and in the lives of all the messengers, these two points are common factors and spiritual invitations is firmly based upon these two points. However Nabi Ibraheem ؑ is the first person in this world who had to pass through very heavy trials and tests and had to combat great calamities and through all these trials he emerged successfully.

Just think for a moment. At very old age after numerous *Du'as* and numerous hopes and desires a child is born. The child is still in its infant stage when an order from Allah comes: "O Ibraheem ؑ, take the mother and child, cross the desert till you reach a valley in which there is no vegetation and leave them there."

Thereafter what happens? Did Ibraheem ؑ hesitate even for a moment before carrying out this order? Did he put forth any excuse? No, nothing, he immediately left to leave the mother and child there where the *Kabah* now stands. After that when the child reaches the age of reason and discernment when he has become the refreshment of the eyes to his parents, again comes and order to sacrifice

the child in the Name of Allah to show his obedience to Allah.

At such a time the most obedient one and the most righteous one will find himself some what in a dilemma with at least a bit of hesitation. And even though the revelation came in the form of a dream shown to him, he never tried to interpret it in a different way, but without any hesitation he took his beloved son the next day with the aim of carrying out the order, showing his faithfulness.

The third test was when Namrud, his father and the people passed a unanimous judgement against him that he should desist from preaching his message or he would be cast into a blazing fire. In the face of the unanimity among them one would expect Ibraheem (*Alaihis Salām*)'s feel to hesitate, but this never happened. He was as steadfast as a mountain as he continued to preach the truth and convey the message just as before. The enemies then did what they threatened to do and cast him into a blazing fire. In Ibraheem ؑ there was no difference in his dignified resolve and determination. However Allah frustrated all their plans and efforts as the flames of the fire were made 'cool and safe' for Ibraheem ؑ. Thereafter under the protection of Allah he continued to enlighten the servants of Allah and became even more diligent in conveying the message.

Apart from Ibraheem (*Alaihis Salām*)'s various tests and his steadfastness during those tests there is another speciality in the make up of Nabi Ibraheem ؑ and that is in the contrasting lives of *Shirk* and *Tauheed*, he produced such a special distinction which could only come forth from a messenger of Allah like himself. In his condemnation of idol worship and worship of the heavenly bodies, he clearly announced:

"For me, I have set my face firmly and truly towards Him who created the heavens and the earth and never shall I give partners unto God."

(6:79)

The meaning of this exclamation is that there are two views regarding Allah one the right view and secondly the wrong one.

The wrong view is this that it is believed that to acquire Allah's pleasure and to keep Him happy and to worship him properly, one will have to also worship the idols, and heavenly bodies for when these are pleased with us, they will make Allah be happy and pleased with us.

This belief is '*Shirk*' or '*Saubi'at*'. It means that all the worship which is for Allah alone and should be so, is shared also with others. That is the reality of '*Shirk*.'

In contrast to that is the correct path according to which one should have this belief that the only way of acquiring Allah's pleasure and satisfaction is that one should worship Him consider Him as the solver of our problems and the granter of our needs. He is the one in whose hands lie benefit and our harm or losses, our health and our illnesses, our poverty and our wealth, our sustenance in abundance or in inadequate amount, our life and our death. In other words One should accept that in all our affairs. He is the doer with complete freedom to do as He sees fit. Then also to acquire knowledge of His pleasure and displeasure one should act according to the teachings of the messengers whom He sent to this world. What this means is that to acquire Allah's pleasure and to attain nearness to Him there is no need to make the idols our intermediaries or intercessors, but just to worship Him alone. This is the belief of Islam and this is the upright religion.

This is the distinction Nabi Ibraheem  made between *Shirk* and *Imān*.

It became the foundation stone on which the following Prophets built until the final Prophet Muhammad  called his religion the "upright religion" and also named his follows 'Muslims.'

"And follow the way of Ibraheem  the true in faith."
(4:125)

"Ibraheem  has named you Muslim and so also in this Qur'ān."
(22:78)

This is the reason why there is this speciality in *Surah Ibraheem* that in it the advent of the Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) and their personalities have been described as well as their general results and in it has been given the difference between those who obeyed and accepted their calls and invitation to guidance and those who rejected their invitations.

So bearing all that in mind, we say that among the Prophets and Messengers Nabi Ibraheem  has a position which we may call the Renovator of the Prophets.

Lessons from the Various Incidents

1. When a person has made a firm belief to enter his heart with certainty and that belief has become joined to his soul and been made a firm image within him, thoughts about that belief becomes so strong and steadfast that no happening on earth and no calamity however great will be able to remove it from his breast. He will enter a fire with pleasure or dive into a deep ocean without hesitation and fearlessly step onto the steps leading to crucifixion. The example of Nabi Ibraheem  is a living example thereof.

2. In support of the truth such arguments should be cited which will enter the hearts and minds of enemies and followers of falsehood so that they may not admit by tongue, but their hearts will be forced to declare, the truth reluctantly and at times the tongue will unintentionally declare. In the following verse this is what is meant: "And dispute with them in the best manner."
3. It is the way of the Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) and Messengers that they do not utilize the arguments of logic in their disputes with people. Their arguments concern observations and things that are perceivable and they refer to simple rational things. Nabi Ibraheem (*Alaihis Salām*)'s debate with his people about idol worship and worship of the stars and heavenly bodies is a clear example thereof.
4. In the effort to prove a truth, if one makes use of for the sake of argument accepting his wrong belief, this does not mean one's acceptance of wrong beliefs. In debating it is a strategy used for the purpose of making the opponent see his mistake and admitting to it. Nabi Ibraheem عليه السلام used this method in his debate with the general public the idol worshippers so that they had to admit that the idols could not hear and were unable to answer.
5. Even if one's father is an idol-worshipper and not prepared under any circumstances to discard idol worship then one should stay clear of his life of 'Shirk', but in worldly and spiritual affairs it will still be necessary to deal with him in a soft manner with kind advice. It will still not be permissible to act harshly towards him. The manner in which Nabi

Ibraheem  treated his father and the way in which Rasulullah  treated Abu Taalib are living examples thereof.

6. When a believer has faith in his heart and in his tongue, but he does not have a physical observation of that faith which grants complete certainty and then begs for such a demonstration, this is not doubt or disbelief but is in fact actual faith as was mentioned by Nabi Ibraheem , ("I do believe, but it is to set my heart at ease)."
7. If a person shows hospitality and generosity to guests without wishing to show off his hospitality to be known for it, this is a sign of kind-heartedness and of his noble character which is also known as generosity.

In some books a story is being told of Ibraheem (*Alaihis Salām*)'s generosity. Once he was standing in the desert awaiting the arrival of a guest. This was so because he was in the habit of never eating alone. From ahead of him he saw an old man coming along leaning on a walking stick with his back bent forward. As he approached Nabi Ibraheem  went forward to welcome him with pleasure and brought him home. They ate and when they had finished eating, Ibraheem  said: "Now let us express thanks to that Being who granted us all these favours:

"The old man, becoming angry replied: "I do not know who that one Being of yours is, I express thanks to my god, who is kept in my home-my idol."

This reply went down very badly with Ibraheem  and in response he quickly got rid of the old man and sent him forth.

However, not long after that Ibraheem عليه السلام felt sorrow in his heart for having got rid of the old man so quickly. He thought within himself. "The God whom I wanted him to express thanks to-His dealing with this man is such that during this old man's long life, He has continuously blessed him with His bounties and in spite of being displeased with his idol worship, He has not for one day closed down on him the doors of His sustenance. What right did you have, O Ibraheem عليه السلام, that this man has refused to accept your suggestion and you become angry and expel him from your house so quickly?"

Whether this incident is acceptable or not, it still serves to indicate the nobility of character which is an excellent example for others and his thoughts afterwards is in itself a good example.

8. When Allah chooses anyone for the purpose of spreading the truth, he enlightens their heart so much with His Noor that in their sight nothing can replace the love for truth and nothing else matters. The result is that from the beginning the preparedness and preparation is placed in them with the result that since their age of childhood they appear eminent and distinguished above their contemporaries. They willingly under go trials and tests in the path of truth and in patience and for bearance they set a fine example. The story of Hazrat Ismail عليه السلام is a good witness of this and holds many lessons for us.
9. Nabi Loot عليه السلام, although he was a nephew of Hazrat Ibraheem عليه السلام and a follower, was also endowed with prophethood and had been made Allah's ambassador Hence in Sodom and Gamoro he was made to suffer great hardships but in spite of that he remained patient

and steadfast and instead of calling upon the help of his uncle and family, relied only on Allah. He persevered in his efforts with complete resignation. Through that he reached the rank of the 'nearest ones to Allah' among the Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*).

Hazrat Yaqoob

Name and Nasab

Sayeduna Yaqoob  was the second son of Nabi Ishaq  and is the grandson of Nabi Ibraheem . In the Hebrew Language Hazrat Yaqoob ; name is given as 'Israa'eel' This word is made up of 'Israa' which means slave or bondsman and 'Eel' which means Allah. In Arabic this word be Abdullah-'bondsman of Allah' For this reason the children of Ibraheem  through his son Ishaq  who are the offspring of Nabi Ya'qoob  are called 'Bani Israa'eel.'

Mention of Ya'qoob in the Qur'ān

In the Qur'ān the name of Ya'qoob  is mentioned ten times in *Surah Yusuf* in various places he is mentioned either through pronouns referring to him or through description of him. In other *Surahs* he is mentioned by description. The Qur'ān draws attention to his being a prominent and eminent Nabi with great 'sabr' and steadfastness. He was a chosen Prophet of Allah sent to the people of Can'aan He was involved with his prophetic Duties for Many years.

He had twelve sons but their story will appear under the history of Nabi Yusuf  which in coming right now.

Hazrat Yusuf عليه السلام

Nasab

Hazrat Yusuf عليه السلام was the son of Nabi Ya'qoob عليه السلام and is the great grandson of Nabi Ibraheem عليه السلام. He has this honour that he was a Nabi, his father was a Nabi, his grandfather, Ishaq was a Nabi and his great grand father was the father of the *Ambiyaa*.

In the Qur'ān he is mentioned by name 26 times and another speciality of his is that a special *Surah* in the Qur'ān is named after him. This *Surah*, *Surah Yusuf* is a collection of many lessons and for this reason the story of Nabi Yusuf عليه السلام has been called *Ahsanul-Qasas* 'the best of stories.'

Yusuf's Dream and His Brothers

Right from his childhood days Yusuf (*Alaihis Salām*)'s mental and natural qualities were superior to those of his other brothers. In fact Nabi Ya'qoob عليه السلام having seen the *Noor* shining on his fore-head recognised the *Noor* of Prophethood and had been informed through Divine Revelation of his coming prophethood. For this reason among all his children he had the greatest love and affection for Yusuf عليه السلام. This love and affection for Yusuf عليه السلام caused his other brothers great anguish and they were all the time

busy thinking of ways to either remove this love from the heart of Ya'qoob عليه السلام or to remove Yusuf عليه السلام out of the way to be rid of him.

While they were involved in these thoughts of jealousy, it so happened that Yusuf عليه السلام saw a dream wherein eleven stars and the sun and the moon were performing *Sujood* in front of him.

When the father heard of this dream he strongly advised his son not to relate the dream to anyone because it is possible that if the brother came to know of it they may react in a bad way; as *Shaitan* is at all times trying to cause mischief. This dream's interpretation was clear but the brothers had been influenced by their Jealousy to plan against Yusuf عليه السلام:

"One of them said: slay not Yusuf but if ye must do something, throw him down to the bottom of a well. He will be picked up by some caravan of travellers."

(12:10)

After this advice they all gathered and went to Ya'qoob عليه السلام and said:

"O our father, why do you not trust us with Yusuf?

Seeing we are indeed his sincere well-wishers?"

(12:12)

Nabi Ya'qoob عليه السلام immediately understood that there was false hood and deceit in their hearts. He said: "It saddens me that you should take him away I fear lest the wolf should devour him while you attend no to him."

(12:13)

Hearing this the brothers said: "If the wolf were to devour him while we are (so strong) a party, then should we indeed first have perished ourselves." (and would have lost everything).

(12:14)

The Well of Canaan

The brothers of Yusuf عليه السلام took him with the aim of taking him for an outing then according to the advice given among them they put him down a drywell without water. On the way back they took his shirt and covered it in blood from an animal, came to their father, crying and said:

"O father, He went racing with one another and left Yusuf with our things; And the wolf devoured him.

But you will never believe us, even though we tell the truth." (12:17)

Nabi Yaqoob عليه السلام looked at the shirt and saw it covered in blood, but it was not torn anywhere. He immediately understood what happened, but instead of scolding them or being sarcastic, he chose the way of the Messengers and with intuition.

He said:

"Nay, but your minds have made up a tale (that may pass) with you: For me patience is most fitting.

Against that which you assert, It is Allah (alone) whose help can be sought." (12:18)

Yusuf عليه السلام into Slavery

While this conversation was taking place a caravan from the Ismailis of Hijaz was en route to Egypt from Syria. When they saw the well, they decided to look for water in it and let down a bucket for water. When they saw Yusuf عليه السلام they shouted with glee:

"Ah, Good news, here is a fine young man."

And so the merchants from the Ismaili caravan made him their slave and took him with their goods to Egypt. In the market of Egypt they put him up for sale. Just at that time a man from the Royal family passed that way. He was Potiphar, an officer of the king's forces. He bought Yusuf and brought him home to his wife and said:

"Make his stay among us honourable. Maybe he will bring us much good, or we shall adopt him as a son.

This Potiphar kept Yusuf عليه السلام in his house with honour like a son and he put all the affairs and responsibilities in his hands.

"Thus did we establish Yusuf عليه السلام in the land that we might teach him the interpretation of stories and events.

And Allah has power and control over His affairs but most among mankind know it not." (12:21)

Yusuf عليه السلام and the Wife of Potiphar

After being cast into the well and after being sold into slavery a third treat was now to come over Yusuf عليه السلام. It was his time of youth and in him there was no aspect which was not endowed with beauty. The wife of Potiphar was unable to keep herself aloof from him and lost her heart to him. She fell in love with him, but he who was predestined for Prophet hood, how could he succumb to her evil intentions. In the Qur'ān story which unfolded is told in these terms:

"And she in whose house he was sought to seduce him from his self.

She fastened the doors and said: "Now come thou (dear one).

He said: "God forbid. I seek God's refuge."

(12:23)

Yusuf  ran away to the door and she followed him and tore his shirt from the back and some how the door opened with the master and his cousin standing there. She quickly spoke:

"What is the fitting punishment for one who formed an evil design against your wife, but prison or a grievous chastisement?"

He said: "It was she that sought to seduce me from my self."

One man from wife's family gave the verdict: "If his shirt is torn from the front, then she is truthful in what she says and if his shirt is torn from the back, then he is the truthful one, and she is the liar."

When they looked, they found the shirt torn from the back. He said to her:

"Undoubtedly O woman, this is your deceit and plan. Yusuf  you are excused. O woman seek pardon for your fault, you are the faulty one."

(12:25—29)

The Master, in order to avoid any scandal finished the matter of there and then but somehow the story did not remain a secret. The Qur'ān states:

"When the news spread, some of the women in the town started saying: "The wife of Aziz has tried to seduce her bands-man She has

fallen in love with him. In our mind she has made a great in discession."

When the Aziz's wife heard this she invited them to her place and according to their customs, spread cushions on the floor for them to sit upon and placed in front of each one of them a knife. Then she told Yusuf عليه السلام: "Go into among them."

When those ladies saw him, they all were so impressed by his beauty that they took the knives and cut their hands. Unwittingly they exclaimed:

"This is no human being. This must be a high ranking angel."
(12:30—33)

There upon the Aziz's wife said to them: "Have you seen him? This is that man about which you have taunted me."

She continued: "Indeed I have tried to take control of his heart but he did not respond to my efforts."

But "I say, If he does not listen to my demands, he will be imprisoned and will be dishonoured."

When Yusuf عليه السلام heard this, and saw the conduct of the Aziz's wife and the other women, he prayed to Allah:

"O My Lord, the thing to which they call me—the inside of the prison is more preferable to me and if you do not ward off from me their plans, and if you do not help me, I may be inclined towards them and thereby join the ranks of the ignorant."

So his Lord hearkened unto him (in his prayer) and turned away from him their snare.

Verily He heareth and knoweth (all things) (12:34)

Now the Aziz having seen all the signs from Yusuf and having noticed the scandal in which his wife was involved, decided that best would be to imprison Yusuf for a time until such time that the story is removed from the minds of people and so Yusuf عليه السلام had to go to jail.

Yusuf عليه السلام in Prison

It is mentioned in the Torah that even in jail Yusuf (*Alaihis Salâm*)'s intellectual ability and in action too he could not be silenced. The jailor entered into his sphere of influence and all the management affairs of the jail was left in his hands and he was free to do inside the prison as he wished.

Tableegh in Jail

It was a greatly fortunate that two other prisoners entered jail with him. One was the King's wine-maker and the other was the head-baker of the Royal palace. One day both of them came to Yusuf عليه السلام and the wine-maker said: "I have seen a dream wherein I saw myself pressing grapes."

The other said:

"I have seen a dream where in I carry a basket of bread on my head, while the birds eat the bread."

Hearing this Yusuf عليه السلام replied: "Undoubtedly of the things Allah has taught me is this that he also taught me the interpretation of dreams. I shall inform you of the meaning of your dreams before your food reaches you. But before I come to that I have some thing else to inform you of. Have you thought of this: Are many gods better or the one true God; who is supreme above every thing. Those whom you worship besides Allah are just a few names which you and your fathers have named them. Sovereignty belongs to Allah

alone. He commands that you only worship Him and no one else. This is the straight path but most people do not know."
(12:39—40)

Then after this call towards guidance Yusuf عليه السلام returned to the interpretation of their dreams.

"As for you who saw yourself pressing grapes, you will be set free and will again serve the king as wine-maker. And as for you who saw yourself carrying bread, he will be crucified and the birds will pick at his head and eat it."

When Yusuf عليه السلام had told them the interpretation he told the wine-maker, thinking that he will be saved and set free; "Remember me to your King."

But when the wine-maker was finally set free he became so busy in his affairs that he forgot Yusuf (*Alaihis Salām*)'s claim and Yusuf عليه السلام was forced to remain in prison for a few years.

The King's Dream

While Nabi Yusuf عليه السلام was still in prison it so happened that the king of Egypt also saw a dream, in which seven thin lean cows swallowed seven fat cows. He also saw seven ears of corn which were dry, ate up seven green ears of corn. Soon after this dream the King called all his advisors and asked them to interpret this dream. All of the courtiers were confused at the dream and were unable to do so.

Then the wine-maker remembered how Yusuf عليه السلام had interpreted his dream. He asked the King for a bit of time and he will bring the correct interpretation. With the permission of the King he reached the prison and related the dream to Yusuf عليه السلام, asking for its interpretation. Yusuf

ﷺ immediately gave him the correct interpretation as the Qur'ān states:

"He said: for seven years you shall sow as is your wont and the harvest that you reap, you shall leave them in their ears, except a little of which you shall eat."

"Then will come after that period seven dreadful years which will devour what you shall have laid by in advance for them. Which you shall have guarded."

"Then will come after that a year in which people will have abundant water and in which they will press (wine and oil)."

The wine-maker came and related the interpretation to the King and the King on hearing of the coming period of drought, said:

"Bring you, him unto me."

However when the King's Messenger reached Yusuf, Yusuf refused to leave the prison saying he was not prepared to get out of prison like that:

"Go to your master and ask him to investigate the matter of those women, who cut their hands. Let it fast be known what plans they made. My Lord is quite aware of their plans."

When the King heard this he called those women to him and demanded from them the true story of how they tried to seduce Yusuf. They all replied:

"Allah preserve us! We knew no evil against him."
(12:51)

The wife of the Aziz was also present and when she came to know that it was Yusuf's desire that the truth come out, she declared:

"Now the truth is manifest (to all). It was I who sought to seduce him from his self. He is indeed of those who are (over) true (and virtuous)."

(12:51)

Now the time had arrived when the women all admitted that Yusuf ﷺ was completely innocent of any evil. When the king realized this his respect for Yusuf ﷺ became profound. He said:

"Bring him unto me. I will take him specially to serve about my own person."

In response to this order by the King, Yusuf ﷺ was brought to his court and he said to Yusuf ﷺ:

"Verily today you are, in our preserve, with rank firmly established, and fidelity fully proved."

Then he asked what should be done to combat the effects of the period of starvation that was coming according to the dream's interpretation."

Yusuf ﷺ replied:

"Set me in charge over the store-houses of the land I will indeed guard them. I am one that knows (their importance)."

The King accepted his suggestion and made Yusuf the treasurer and guardian of the Kingdom. The keys to the store houses was given in his hands and he had full control. Allah says: We granted him '*Eamkeen fil Ardi*'. This is mentioned twice. After being granted that high position he

planned to save the people of Egypt from the period of drought and starvation.

The Period of Famine

Finally the period of famine as prophecied by Yusuf ﷺ, arrived. In Egypt and the surrounding areas a great famine arose and so also in Can'aan.

Nabi Yaqoob ﷺ told his sons: "The Aziz of Egypt has announced that they have corn saved for this time. Go to Egypt and buy corn there."

And so the Caravan from Canaan set forth for Egypt to buy corn.

And the brothers of Yusuf ﷺ came to Egypt, and when they reached him, Yusuf recognised them while they did not recognise him

According to the Torah the brother were accused of being spies and so they were brought to him face to face and he inquired about the condition of the father and the brother Bin-yameen. When he prepared their goods for departure, he said to them that when they come next time, they should bring along their half brother Bin Yameen. "You have seen how I give full measure and that I am hospitable to those arriving from outside. If you do not bring him along, you will get neither sale from me, nor will you find a place with me." (12:59—60)

He then ordered the servants to secretly place the money they had paid for the corn back in their saddle bags. When they returned to Can'aan they told the whole story to Nabi Yaqoob ﷺ. They also told him how the Governor of Egypt had clearly warned them that they will not be sold any corn next time unless Bin Yameen comes along. Therefore

the father should send him along the next time. They promised to look after him and protect him at all times.

Yaqoob عليه السلام replied:

"Shall I trust you with him as I trusted his brother Yusuf عليه السلام with you before this? Allah is the best protector and He is the Most Merciful of those who show Mercy."

Then they began to open their luggage and found their money which had been returned to them: They said: "O father what more do we want than this? Give us permission to return to him once more to bring corn and allow Bin Yameen to go with us. We will protect him."

Yaqoob عليه السلام replied:

"I will never send him with you unless you give me your promise on a solemn oath."

There after, after they had sworn a solemn oath the caravan left once more for Egypt with Bin Yameen with them. At the time of parting Nabi Yaqoob عليه السلام said to them:

"O My sons do not enter from one gate but enter by different gates..."

"And when they entered Egypt in the manner suggested by their father, this precaution did not help at all except that it was just a necessity of Yaqoob (*Alaihis Salām*)'s soul which he discharged. Indeed was he a man of knowledge and we taught him this knowledge But most people do not know."

(12:68)

In the mean time when the brother left Canaan, they began to cause Bin Yameen quite a bit trouble. They scorned

him for the love the father had for him and expressed jealousy at the way in which the Aziz of Egypt made a special point of calling for him to be brought along. But when they reached Egypt:

"And when they came to Yusuf ﷺ, Yusuf ﷺ made his brother to sit by his side and told him secretly: "I am your brother. Do not be sad at the bad manner in which they treat you." (12:69)

After a few days the Canaany Caravan started to depart. Yusuf ﷺ commanded that their camels be so loaded as much as they could carry. He also wanted his brother to remain with him by any possible means, but the law in Egypt at that time was that it was prohibited to allow a non-Egyptian to remain behind without a good and acceptable reason. More over Yusuf ﷺ did not at that time wish to expose the truth. And so when the Caravan left he ordered someone to hide the royal goblet in Bin Yameen's bag.

The Caravan had only travelled a short distance when an official from Yusuf (Alaihis Salām)'s side came behind and shouted:

"O men of this Caravan, you are thieves."

They replied: "What is it that you miss?"

He said: "We Miss the goblet of the King.

For him who produces it is (the reward of) a camel load. I will be bound by it."

They replied: "By Allah you know we did not come here to commit mischief in Egypt and we are not thieves."

The official said: "What is the punishment if you are found to be untruthful?"

They replied: "The punishment is this that he in whose luggage the goblet is found, he will have to go as punishment that is the way we punish wrong doers."

They started to search the luggage of the Caravan and the goblet was found in the saddle-bag of Bin-Yameen."

Allah says:

"Thus did we plot for Yusuf. He could not take his brother by the law of the King except God willed it so."
(12:76)

In this way Binyameen was kept back in Egypt. The brothers saw this and remembered the oath they swore to their father. They tried their utmost to make the Aziz to allow Binyameen to depart with them. When all that proved unsuccessful they resolved among themselves to inform the father of the true happenings.

Then for the truth he could inquire from other travellers. With this consultation they returned to Canaan to tell Nabi Yaqoob ﷺ the truth.

Yaqoob ﷺ had already experienced the truth from then in the affair of Yusuf ﷺ.

He said:

"May but you have contrived a story (good enough) for you. So patience is most fitting for me."

May be Allah will bring them back to me.

For He is indeed full of knowledge and wisdom.

And he turned away from them and said: "How great is my grief for Yusuf ﷺ!"

And his eyes became white with sorrow and he fell into silent melancholy."

The sons, seeing this sorrow, said:

"By Allah never will you cease to remember Yusuf until you reach the last extremity of illness or until you die."

Sayeduna Yaqoob ﷺ replied:

"I only complain of my distraction and anguish to Allah and I know from Allah that which you do not know."

He continued:

"O My sons go you and inquire about Yusuf ﷺ and his brother and never give up hope of Allah's Mercy. Truly no one despairs of Allah's Mercy except those truly no one despairs of Allah's Mercy except those who have no faith."

The brothers for the third time decided to go to Egypt and on reaching the King's court expressed their big problem, asking for special kindness and mercy. Nabi Yusuf having listened to their distress and his heart was deeply affected so much so that he felt he could no longer hide the truth from them. At last he said:

"Do you know how you dealt with Yusuf ﷺ and his brother, not knowing what you were doing?"

Hearing this unexpected conversation, they said:

"Are you indeed Yusuf ﷺ?"

He replied:

"Yes I am Yusuf عليه السلام and this is my brother. Allah has been gracious to us. Verily he who is righteous and patient, never will Allah suffer the reward to be lost of those who do right."

On hearing this the brothers said:

"By Allah, Indeed has Allah preferred you above us.

And we certainly have been guilty of sin."

Nabi Yusuf عليه السلام saw this distressed state of his brothers and the prophetic mercy in him was stirred. He said to them: "This day let no reproach be cast on you. Allah will forgive you and He is the most Merciful of all those who show Mercy."

He also said to them:

"Go back to Canaan and take this shirt of mine put it on my father's eyes. Inshallah the light of his eyes will return. And bring the whole family to Egypt."

(12:93)

While all this happened and while the Caravan was on route from Egypt with the shirt of Yusuf عليه السلام, Nabi Yaqoob عليه السلام was through Divine Revelation getting the smell of Yusuf عليه السلام. He exclaimed: "If you are not going to tell me that old age had affected my reason, then I would say with certainty that I get the smell of Yusuf عليه السلام."

They all replied: "You are still in your previous madness."

After such a long time you still just think of him."

When the Caravan finally arrived that happened which Yusuf عليه السلام fore told.

"Then when the bearer of the good news came,
He cast the shirt over his face and forth with
regained clear sight."

He asked them: "Did I not say to you I know from Allah
that which you know not."

For the brothers of Yusuf ﷺ this was very difficult time.
They were deeply ashamed and regretful and with heads bent
in shame they uttered:

"O father, seek Allah's pardon on our behalf.
Indeed were we great sinner."

Hazrat Ya'qoob ﷺ replied: "I shall pray to Allah for
your forgiveness very soon. He is greatly Beneficient, and
Merciful. (12:98)

The Family of Yaqoob ﷺ in Egypt

Nabi Ya'qoob ﷺ took his whole family and proceeded
to Egypt. According to the Torah they were seventy persons
in all. When Yusuf ﷺ came to know that his family were
enroute to Egypt he quickly came out to welcome them.

When Nabi Yaqoob ﷺ saw his beloved son after such a
long time he embraced him and held him against his breast.
Then he said: "Now you enter Egypt in safety and with honour."

Carrying them on royal carriages, he brought them to
the town and made them get off at the royal palace. Then a
special court session was held. The father was made to sit at
the Royal throne. Then Nabi Yusuf ﷺ himself went to sit on
the throne. Then according to the custom of the time all the
courtiers fell into prostration before the throne. (Perhaps this
form of honouring was permissible in the earlier eras of the
Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*). Rasulullah ﷺ has declared this

kind of honouring prohibited for this *Ummat* and only declared it permissible for Allah alone.)

The whole family of Yusuf عليه السلام did the same and on seeing this, Yusuf عليه السلام remembered the dream he had seen in his childhood and said to his father:

"O father, this is the meaning of the dream which I saw long ago. My Lord has caused it to come true."

Nabi Yusuf عليه السلام then prayed:

"O My Lord, You have granted me governance and have taught me the meanings of dreams and events. O Creator of heavens and earth, You are my Protector in this world and the here after. Let me pass away as a Muslim, submitting unto you and join me in the ranks of the righteous ones."

(12:101)

According to the Torah Nabi Yusuf (*Alaihis Salām*)'s whole family came to settle in Egypt.

Death of Yusuf عليه السلام

Nabi Yusuf عليه السلام spent a large part of his life in Egypt and he passed away in Egypt at the age of one hundred and ten years. When he died he was embalmed and placed in a coffin. And so it remained until the time of Nabi Musa عليه السلام, when according to his *Wassiyat*, Bani Israel left Egypt, they took the coffin with the body with them and came to bury it in the land of his fore father's i.e. Canaan. It is said his grave is to be found in the neighbourhood of Nablus in Palestine which today falls in Israel.

Matters of Islamic Ethics

1. When a person's personal nature is good and his environment is kept clean and holy, then that person will become known for being a man of noble character and high qualities and he will be endowed with all honourable manners.
2. If a person is steadfast in his belief in Allah and that faith has become very strong, then all the obstacles in his path becomes easy to overcome and after seeing the truth, all those dangers and difficulties become like nothing in his eyes.
3. Whether trials and tests are in the form of calamities or forms of destruction, or whether in the form of wealth or whether in the form of good-seeming ways of acquiring lustful desires, a man should at all times take refuge in Allah and beg of him to grant us steadfastness and strength.
4. When the love of Allah enters into the heart and his lore enters all corners of our hearts, that love becomes the very object of his life and it becomes his second nature at all times to convey Allah's message which virtually flows in all his veins and arteries.
5. Honesty and trust worthiness is such a quality and favour from Allah which may be said to be the key to worldly and spiritual happiness.
6. Self-reliance is one of the highest human qualities. To whosoever Allah has given this quality, he on passing through all worldly calamities will reach high rank in worldly and in spiritual matters.
7. Patience is a very great quality and acts as a shield against many evils. In the Qur'ān the virtues of

patience has been expounded in more than sixty places and Allah has made the acquisition of high rank subject to its presence.

8. To prefer patience and tolerance at the time when trouble-some brothers show regret is a sign of good-hearted ness.
9. Among the good qualities a very good one is gratitude because it is one of the highest Divine qualities.
10. Hatred and jealousy are qualities which are harmful to those who practise them. And although the one who is hated and the one of whom one is jealous some times suffer losses, but still the one who hates or who is jealous do not find success and as is stated in the Qur'ān, he loses both the world and the hereafter, unless he repents of his hatred and stops his activities which are done through jealousy.
11. A life of truth, honesty and trustworthiness, patience and gratitude and such high qualities is a life of true success and if a man does not hold these qualities within him, he is not a man, but an animal and is in fact worse.

The life of Hazrat Yusuf عليه السلام is an illustration of all these high qualities and his life is an invitation to those qualities.'

"O My Lord, Creator of heavens and earth you are my Protector in this world and the Hereafter. Let me die as a Muslim submitting to you in obedience And join me in the ranks of the righteous ones."

(12:101)

QASASUL AMBIYAA

STORIES OF THE PROPHETS

Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy (Rah.)



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Qasasul Ambiyaa

(Stories of the Prophets)

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Qasasul Ambiyaa

The Holy Qur'ān does not relate historical facts merely for the sake of telling a story which is of historical value. Its main aim in relating happenings is to draw attention to the results, conclusions and deductions from these incidents so that they become a source of guidance for men and prove to be lessons for them that appeal to their minds and emotions that from these historical events, lessons should be derived. These lessons should convince them that the existence of Allah is an undeniable fact and that His Mighty Hand is playing a major role in the affairs of men. It should also bring to their notice that to follow the stipulations of His deen brings success and leads to salvation and is the way towards all progress. That is what Islām—the natural religion—is about.

From: Qasasul Qur'ān

Preface

The most authentic and comprehensive work of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy, *Qasasul Qur'ān* needs no introduction. However, the Manner in which our friend Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version of a voluminous and bulky work he has undoubtedly, fulfilled one of the needs of this time. He has adopted such a method of abridgement whereby not only has he retained and mentioned every important fact in the lives of the Holy Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) and other saintly personalities, which are of lessons to men, but also discussed in brought outline some other important matters. It is hoped that with Allah's grace, those persons who are occupied and busy at all times, will be able to derive adequate benefit from this work.

The great effort of Sayed Tanzeem Hussain in this old age of his is really something praiseworthy. May Allah reward him well for this great effort.

Qari Sayed Rasheedul-Hasan Hussainy Nadwi

Imam and Khateeb

Jama Masjid, New Town

Allamah Binori Town, Karachi

P5 Muharram, 1308 Hijri

Publisher's Foreword

The respected personality of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy is one of the most eminent Ulama of the Indo-Pak Sub-Continent. His most approved and well-known book, *Qasasul-Qur'ān* is considered to be a unique publication on this subject. The point that distinguishes it from other similar books is the fact that after every story, Maulana has made use of deep thought and reflection to present to the readers the lessons and points of guidance from the related episodes. Thus for the teachers and lecturers at *Deeni Madressas* and for preachers in mosques and students of deen the study and perusal of this book is of utmost benefit.

The original book appeared in four volumes with over 1800 pages of subject matter. Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version there of in only 600 pages and this has been met with a verdict of approval from all academic circles, especially by virtue of the fact that he has fulfilled one of the most pressing needs of the time and by leaving aside unimportant discussions have given the busy and occupied ones also a chance to benefit from these work. May Allah reward him well.

Author's Foreword

All praise be to Allah who has guided us with the Holy Book and revealed to us the Qur'ān in a clear Arabic language and in it. He related the best of stories as an admonition and a reminder for the believers. And May peace and blessings be upon the Most truthful and trustworthy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, the messenger of Allah and seal of all the Prophets and upon his offspring, and companions who were all of them guiding stars for all the righteous ones.

Among the inimitable ways in which Allah has chosen for the sake of the guidance of men, is this that attention is drawn to the good and bad deeds of nations and the resultant fruits of such deeds of which they are reminded so that those deeds may be a lesson for men. For this reason those stories are not being related in a style as is generally done in history. The major aim is to convey the truth and to invite to Allah and with this in mind attention is only drawn to those aspects which furthers this objective. For this reason there is constant repetition so that these events can sink into the hearts and minds of listeners and they become attentive towards them. This sinking in and attentiveness can only be achieved if the same event is repeated in various ways and styles whereby sleeping faculties are woken up.

The Qur'ānic stories and events deal mostly with previous nations and the Messengers of Allah (*Alaihimus*

Salām) who were sent to them and bit by bit other matters also become included there-in, mostly dealing with the arguments over good and bad and the battles between the friends of Allah and the friends of *Shaitan*, which in itself proves to be a great lesson and admonishment for me.

But, leaving others aside, there are today so few Muslims who derive benefit from Allah's last and perfect law-book, the Qur'ān, to fill our hearts with *Iman* and *Yaqeen*. After all it is Allah's law and we are commanded to implement its orders in our lives, Moreover we are required to ponder over its meanings as this Qur'ān is the means forwards acquiring success and salvation in both this world and the here after.

At the time of the Revelation of the Qur'ān, the Messenger of Allah became so distressed and defected at the enmity and opposition of the polytheists that he raised this complaint to Allah:

(5:25—30)

However, in this 15th century, if we should examine our hearts, we will find that in spite of our claims to be Muslims and believing the Qur'ān to be the word of Allah, how few are who have made this word of Allah the pattern for their lives and the model on which to base their lives, who read and recited with this aim in mind?

It was my aim, seeing this condition of my people and myself, to translate this great source of admonition into Urdu so that by presenting the translated version, the hearts of people will automatically become drawn to the original i.e., the Qur'ān and thereby acquire everlasting happiness.

In spite of my simple style of writing, care has been taken to confine myself to a few special points.

- (a) In this book the basis for all the stories is the Holy Qur'ān and the authentic *Hadith* and these have been further elucidated with historical facts.
- (b) Where there appears any contradiction or differences in the stories as told in the old testament and the Qur'ān, then with clear arguments an effort has been made either to reconcile the versions or with clear arguments to prove the truth as is expounded in the Qur'ān.
- (c) An effort has been made to point out the nonsensical Israili stories and where there have been nonsensical objections from enemies, these have in the light of the true facts been made clear for what they are.
- (d) In some special places there have been introduced some discussions on matters of disputes in *Tafseer* and *Hadith* and after discussing these the views of the saintly elders have been mentioned as a solution.
- (e) The facts concerning every Prophet ﷺ and in which chapter of the Qur'ān they are mentioned, has been gathered in one place.
- (f) Lastly, together with all the above points, a special heading of "Results and lessons", is introduced, giving the actual objective of this book and its main purpose viz., admonition and warning. Special attention is drawn to this aspect.

Servant of the Millat

Muhammad Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy

22 Rajab, 1360 Hijri

Translator's Foreword

For me as the translator of this book by Maulana Hifzur Rahman is a great honour. Throughout my student days in Darul Uloom Deoband in India, Maulana Hifzur Rahman or as we know him then as the *Mujahid-e-Millat* was one of the most respected leaders of the Muslim community. We used to flock to listen to his most interesting lectures. And as the general secretary of the *Jamiatul-Ulama*, and a M.P. he was also a great 'Alim (scholar) as can be gauged from this book *Qasasul Ambiya* (Tales of the Prophets) which entailed great research. I can remember whenever the students were confronted with any problem in the lives of any of the prophets, they always took refuge in Maulana's book for answers. I took upon it as a great honour in being in some small manner associated with Maulana's scholarship, even though this is an abridged version of the original book. But I must also state that I found great difficulty in translating this book because of the exceptionally high quality of the Urdu language used in the book.

I hope that the English translation of Maulana Hifzur Rahman's scholarly work will also be of great benefit to the English-speaking people. I just hope that I have been able to do justice to the original thoughts of the author.

Yusuf Karaan
Strand, South Africa